And for some activists and opposition leaders, unity and protection of the majority are an inviolable platform from which any debate about democracy — or communal violence — must take place. Likewise, it is of little surprise that the values of universal human rights and the protection of minorities play a pivotal role in the narratives of democratization drawn on by many Western aid workers.

Yet this research shows that while Gallie's (1956) ideas of essential contestability can be valuable in making sense of different reactions to communal violence, this study did not reveal competition over rival uses of "democracy" as always "progressive". Rather, debate over "democracy" and appropriate responses to communal violence was often portrayed as either absent, or regressive rather than progressive. As absolute and conflicting components of the meaning of "democracy" were put forward — for example, human rights versus unity — there was generally seen to be little mutual refinement of arguments. Rather, many participants suggested they could no longer debate the issue. Questions of how to respond to communal violence may be so difficult to discuss in aid programs because of differing inviolable assumptions about the nature of democracy.

Explaining the reactions of Aung San Suu Kyi or Burmese activists as either disingenuous, or as a sign of being "crazy", fails to appreciate the many different narratives about the country's democratization. Yet recognition of rival meanings of "democracy" may not necessarily lead to reconciliation of positions. And, in fact, attention to the contested nature of "democracy" can reveal that different positions are even more irreconcilable than we may have hoped. Portraying opposing positions as either irrational or insincere at least provides some finality; recognizing them as alternative forms of democratic thinking can be far more perplexing.

Notes

1 This research involved fifty interviews with Western aid workers, activists and opposition political party leaders conducted in Burmese and English languages by the researcher over a ten-month period in 2013 and 2014. The year and language of the interviews is indicated in in-text citations.

2 It should be noted that while this research focused on the democracy movement in Myanmar, it was more specifically targeted to Bamar or Burman activists, or opposition leaders in the movement. The varied perspectives of actors from ethnic minority background were not addressed directly. This could be an important